Door From the Mausoleum of Sultan Al-Ghuri

Mausoleum of Sultan al-Ghuri, Cairo

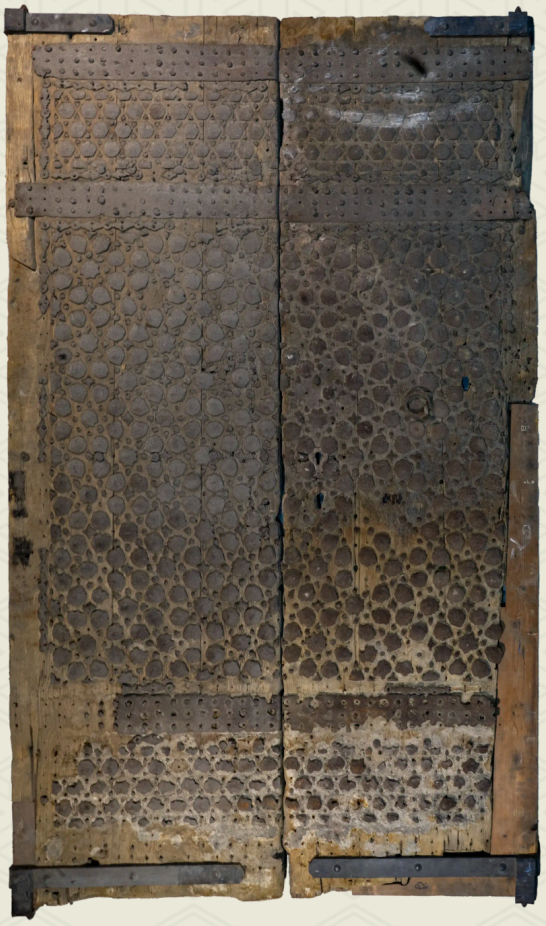
Burji Mamluk, 908-10 AH / 1503-05 CE

Iron and Wood

W. 174 cm, H. 294 cm

Hall 1

Inv. no. 560



The front façade of the door © NADIM Foundation

These large, metal-revetted double doors from the mausoleum of al-Ghuri are organized around a dense, starburst-like field of overlapping eight-pointed stars. Each star is assembled from multiple smaller metal components individually nailed to a wooden backing, creating a contrast between the gleam of the revetment and glimpses of the wood beneath. The composition is framed above and below by broad

horizontal metal bands ornamented with repeating six-pointed stars executed in a similar manner. Particularly striking is the door's markedly fortified character. Unlike the more delicate bronze or brass revetments typical of Mamluk decorated doors, the use of iron lends the surface a weight and severity more closely associated with defensive architecture.

Doors produced under al-Ghuri's patronage encompass a wide variety of forms, each drawing on distinct strands of the Mamluk woodworking and metalworking traditions. The fully revetted ceremonial entrances to his complex on al-Mu'izz Street pay homage to the grandiose entrance to the complex of Sultan Barquq (1385-86) on the same avenue, invoking the legacy of the first Circassian Mamluk sultan at the hands of the last. Both this and the elaborate bukhariyya door at the rear of the madrasa follow a more refined tradition of Mamluk metalwork, where doors were typically executed in brass or bronze, sometimes with silver inlay, and with considerably greater delicacy of casting and carving.



Al-Ghuri complex, c.1920s-1930s. Oriental Commercial Bureau, Port Said, postcard No. 413. From the collection of Youssef ElNahas

The metal-banded door at the side entrance of the mausoleum, by contrast, recalls the monumental city gates of Historic Cairo - Bab al-Nasr, Bab al-Futuh, and Bab Zuwayla - though at a considerably reduced scale. This fortified character was not incidental: al-Ghuri had served in Aleppo and Tarsus before his

sultanate, where Mamluk governors similarly secured the entrances to their khans and wikalas with metal-banded doors, as seen in the khans of Qassabiyya (1510) and Khayrbek (1514) in Aleppo.

The present example occupies a distinct position within this tradition, aligning with the category of armored doors while retaining a decorative flair. In terms of technique, its closest parallel is the front door of the mosque of Ulmas al-Hagib (1329-30), which similarly employs individually nailed metal polygons applied to a wooden backing; the door added by Amir Baktimur al-Jukandar (1303) in the mosque of al-Salih Tala'i, while achieving a comparable aesthetic, does so through altogether different means: a fully metal-revetted surface rather than discrete applied elements. Reformulating these precedents into a new typology that straddles the boundary between defense and display, al-Ghuri's door under consideration may also have anticipated later developments in Ottoman-period commercial architecture, prefiguring the seventeenth- and eighteenth-century doors of the wikalas of al-Sanadiqiyya and Nafisa al-Bayda further along al-Mu'izz Street, as well as a comparable example at the Mashhad al-Husayn.

This typology may itself be read as a symbolic response to the unsettled political climate of al-Ghuri's reign, a period marked by the looming Ottoman threat and the erosion of Red Sea trade revenues following the Portuguese discovery of the Cape of Good Hope route. Significantly, both al-Ghuri's wikala at Khan al-Khalili and his gateway at Sikkat al-Qabwa are explicitly described as fortresses (hisn) in their foundation inscriptions, a rhetoric of strength echoed in the resolute material language of this iron-and-wood door. Whether it represents a deliberate innovation of al-Ghuri's patronage, conceived in response to the precarious conditions of his reign, or a later addition to the building, remains a question that further investigation may help to resolve.

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